

## Lesson 8

# Case Study: Cross-cultural Meeting



## Warm-Up

### Motivation Questions:

- Why is effective communication crucial in cross-cultural meetings?
- Can you think of a situation where cultural differences led to misunderstandings in a meeting?
- How can understanding cultural differences improve teamwork and productivity?





## Role-play

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**Scenario:** A team meeting involving members from two different cultures: a German participant (Anna) and a Japanese participant (Kenji) discussing a project timeline.

### **Dialogue:**

**Anna:** Good morning, everyone. I'd like to review the project timeline. I think we need to set clear deadlines to ensure we stay on track.

**Kenji:** Good morning. I agree that deadlines are important, but I believe we should also consider the need for flexibility in our schedule, especially when dealing with unexpected challenges.

**Anna:** Flexibility is good, but I think if we don't set firm deadlines now, we might end up missing our final deadlines later.

**Kenji:** In Japan, we often prefer to create harmony and ensure that everyone is on board. Maybe we can have a checkpoint meeting later in the timeline to reassess our progress.

**Anna:** That sounds reasonable. But I want to ensure that we all take responsibility for our parts. What do you think about setting milestone deadlines?

**Kenji:** I see your point. It might be helpful to have both firm milestones and a flexible approach. How about we discuss this with the entire team and reach a consensus?

### **Role-Play Analysis:**

1. What cultural differences did you notice in the dialogue between Anna and Kenji?
2. How did each participant express their ideas about deadlines?
3. What strategies did Kenji use to address Anna's concerns while maintaining harmony?

## Discussion

- What are some common communication barriers in cross-cultural meetings?
- How can you ensure clear communication when working with colleagues from different cultural backgrounds?
- What strategies can be used to improve cross-cultural understanding and collaboration?



## Practice

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Choose the best answer

- 1. How might the communication style of Indian team members differ from that of American team members in a meeting context?**
  - a) Indian team members prefer indirect communication while American members prefer direct communication.
  - b) Indian team members are always assertive, while American members are quiet.
  - c) American team members use non-verbal cues more often than Indian members.
- 2. In which culture is it common to avoid open confrontation during discussions to maintain group harmony?**
  - a) American
  - b) Indian
  - c) Japanese
- 3. Which of the following best describes decision-making in Japanese culture during meetings?**
  - a) Decisions are made by the individual leader without consulting the group.
  - b) Decisions are reached through a consensus that involves all team members.
  - c) Decisions require majority votes without discussion.

- 4. How is time perceived differently by Indian members compared to American members during meetings?**
- a) Indian members see time as flexible, while American members view it as a strict resource that should be managed carefully.
  - b) Both cultures value punctuality equally.
  - c) Indian members are always on time, while American members are flexible.
- 5. When presenting ideas, which style is likely to be preferred by an American team member versus a Japanese team member?**
- a) Americans tend to rely heavily on data and direct arguments, while Japanese members may use storytelling and illustrations to convey their points.
  - b) Both cultures prefer straightforward and data-driven presentations.
  - c) Japanese members often present first, while American members are more likely to present last.



## Production

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### ACTIVITY 1: DEBATE

#### Instructions:

- Work in pairs.
- Students choose or the coach assigns each pair questions for discussion / debate.
- Try to support your points with examples or research findings.
- Conclude each topic with a summary of key takeaways and any consensus.



### Questions for debate:

1. Should organizations adapt their communication policies to accommodate diverse cultural backgrounds?
2. How should teams address conflicts that arise from cultural misunderstandings? Are there specific strategies that work better in certain cultural contexts?
3. Is adherence to a consensus-based approach more effective than a top-down decision-making style in multicultural teams? Why or why not?
4. How has technology changed the way we navigate cross-cultural communication? Does virtual communication enhance or hinder understanding between different cultures?
5. To what extent should team members be expected to adapt their communication styles to fit the dominant culture of their workplace? Is there a risk of losing authentic expression?
6. Should companies invest more in cultural awareness training for their teams? What benefits could this bring to the organization as a whole?
7. With the increasing globalization of the workforce, what do you think the future holds for cross-cultural teams? What skills will be essential for success in such environments?

### ACTIVITY 2: CROSS-CULTURAL ROLE-PLAY AND DISCUSSION

#### Instructions:

- Students go into groups, each group has members representing a different cultural perspective (Indian, Japanese, American, Vietnamese).
- Each group divides roles to member to role-play a negotiation situation involving a project disagreement within a multicultural team.

#### Negotiation Situation:

*The team needs to finalize the budget for a new project, but each culture has different perspectives on how to allocate resources.*

## Roles:

- **Indian Members:** Focus on building relationships and seeking agreement.
- **Japanese Members:** Prioritize group consensus and indirect communication.
- **American Members:** Push for quick resolution and direct decisions.
- **Vietnamese Leader:** Mediate and encourage discussion.

## Role-Play Instructions:

- Groups will be given 10 minutes to prepare their positions and strategies based on their cultural values.
- Each group will then participate in a structured 15-minute negotiation session where they must discuss and debate budget allocation while adhering to their cultural perspectives.
- The Vietnamese leader will facilitate the discussion and ensure everyone participates

## Debrief:

1. What challenges did you encounter, and how did you overcome them?
2. How did the leader facilitate or hinder effective communication?
3. What strategies could be applied in actual cross-cultural situations to improve outcomes?



## Key Vocabulary

| Target Phrases                                | Use                                                                                                              | Example                                                                                         |
|-----------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b><i>Etiquette</i></b>                       | Refers to the customary code of polite behavior in society or among members of a particular profession or group. | <i>Proper etiquette in business meetings includes punctuality and respectful communication.</i> |
| <b><i>Diplomacy</i></b>                       | The art of managing international relations or dealing with people in a sensitive and effective way.             | <i>Her diplomacy skills helped resolve the conflict between the two departments.</i>            |
| <b><i>Culture</i></b>                         | The ideas, customs, and social behavior of a particular people or society.                                       | <i>Understanding the local culture is essential for successful international business.</i>      |
| <b><i>Global mindset</i></b>                  | The ability to appreciate and understand different cultures, perspectives, and practices around the world.       | <i>Developing a global mindset is crucial for leaders in multinational companies.</i>           |
| <b><i>Misunderstanding</i></b>                | A failure to understand something correctly, often leading to confusion or conflict.                             | <i>There was a misunderstanding about the project deadline, which caused a delay.</i>           |
| <b><i>From my cultural perspective...</i></b> | To introduce an opinion or viewpoint based on one's cultural background.                                         | <i>From my cultural perspective, teamwork and collaboration are highly valued.</i>              |
| <b><i>Let's find common ground.</i></b>       | To suggest identifying shared interests or goals to resolve differences or conflicts.                            | <i>Let's find common ground to ensure both teams are satisfied with the new plan.</i>           |